

always there to help me if I had any challenges. But in Jamaica, I was almost on my own. I learned what independent life meant. I was a girl when I went to Jamaica but became a woman when I left, because I matured so much," she says.

Krishna competed in a number of national-level competitions in Jamaica and even managed to throw a then personal best of 48.27m at the Olympic Destiny Series 3 in Kingston. It was one of a number of performances in Jamaica that eventually helped Krishna earn a scholarship to the University of Texas in El Paso.

But just because she had accomplished her dream of studying and competing in the NCAA didn't mean everything that followed would be smooth sailing. After her first year, she transferred to the University of Nevada, Las Vegas. Just as she made the move, the then throws coach Dorian Scott — who had recruited her in the first place — was relieved of his duties.

For the next year, Krishna was without a coach. Matters worsened after she picked up multiple injuries that prevented her from competing at all. "2023 was very tough for me. There was a span of several months where I had no clarity as to who's going to coach me, what's going to work. Then I ended up fracturing my hand while doing a box jump. Before that, I'd also torn my shoulder when I was leaving the University of Texas at El Paso. It was very strange," she says.

That season, says Krishna, was one of the lowest periods of her athletic career. She worked on improving her mental health and, with sport not in the picture, attempted to focus on her studies — even making the dean's list that year.

While she eventually recovered from her injury and also started working with a new coach, things were slow to improve. Following a poor season, she lost part of her scholarship in 2024 and has had to take up a part-time job.

Currently, Krishna works at a sports stadium to cover some of her expenses while still

maintaining her grade average and training routine. There are days when Krishna admits she questions what she's doing at all. "It's not easy. Some days I'll call my dad or my mother, my sister or my psychologist and I'll be crying. I didn't think I signed up for this. I had a really nice life in Chennai. I was safe, and my mother and father were always there to take care of me. But I always remind myself that I had to take this path. I wanted to be different. I've always felt that life really starts when you step outside your comfort zone," she says.

Turnaround season

Things have begun to turn around for Krishna this year. She's recorded personal bests in both the shot put and the discus — the latter breaking a 26-year-old school record with a throw of 55.22m.

"What helped my technique in both events was that I actually got very strong in the gym. I'm maximising the speed at which I'm making my lifts. That has really helped me. There are also a few technical corrections that Coach Jordan Roach and I have worked on. I'm trying to be as patient as I can when I enter the ring and rotate. I'm also focusing on how I land in the middle. I am trying to land at a particular angle. There were times I would extend myself to the left sector of the ring and foul most of my throws," she says.

That improvement in strength and technique has brought about an

improvement in form that's come at exactly the right time. As an NCAA athlete, she was eligible for five years of competition, meaning the NCAA national finals will be the last outdoor competition of her collegiate career. While her NCAA outdoor season might have ended for now, Krishna has longer-term goals too.

"I definitely want to compete at the 2028 Olympics. I'm going to start my Masters in Sports Management at UNLV, but I will be taking the time to come to India to compete next year so I can make the Indian team for the 2026 Commonwealth and Asian Games. But what I really want to do is compete at the 2028 Olympics," she says.

While the big throws and medals are all great, perhaps what Krishna is most grateful for is the way she now perceives herself. "When I compare myself to who I was when I was 12 or 13 years old, I can't recognise myself. That young girl would constantly seek validation from people. I'd always think, 'Oh my God, should I buy this? Would this look good on me?' Those were constant mental challenges. "But ever since I've started college, I've met people who really envied the way I looked. They saw my achievements and saw my inner beauty as a person. That stood out more than just how my body looked," she says.

There are those from her past who notice her living her best life as well. "A lot of the same people who made fun of me and spoke badly about me are now commenting on my *Instagram* saying how I 'made it'. They've reached out and are saying great things about me. It shouldn't matter, but I smile when I see those messages. When your haters have to talk good about you — that's a W right there," she says.



Looking ahead: While her NCAA outdoor season might have ended for now, Krishna has longer-term goals too, like competing in the Commonwealth and Asian Games and the Olympics.